

Critical Items Diagram

Surface the assumptions most critical and most uncertain

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

A Critical Items Diagram plots the assumptions behind a concept on two axes — how **critical** each is to success and how **uncertain** it is — so the team can prioritise testing the assumptions that are both essential and unknown. It directs scarce validation effort where risk is highest.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Part of the HPI/Stanford-derived design toolkit; related to Bland and Osterwalder's assumptions-mapping practice.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Teams often test what is easy rather than what matters. Ranking assumptions by criticality and uncertainty focuses experimentation on make-or-break unknowns.

HOW IT IS USED

List all assumptions, plot each on the critical × uncertain grid, and design cheap tests for those in the high-critical, high-uncertain corner first.

WHEN IT IS USED

Before prototyping and testing, and when planning implementation risk.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Product teams, founders and innovation managers.

FIGURE 1 · PROCESS VIEW

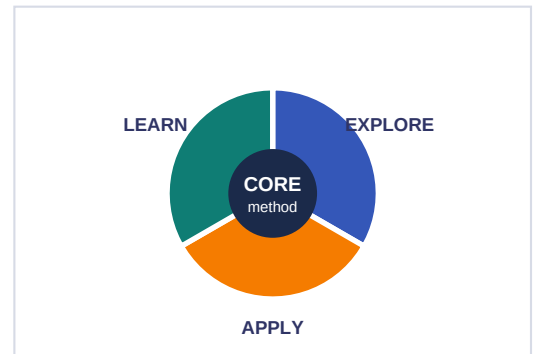


Figure 1. Critical Items Diagram framed as a continuous, iterative method — explore, apply and learn cycle back through the work rather than run once.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It brings **risk triage** to design thinking, ensuring the first tests attack the assumptions most likely to kill the idea.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Minimum Viable Product (MVP) *Slibrary 8*

Define Success *Slibrary 10*

Context Mapping *Slibrary 6*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Lewrick, M., Link, P. and Leifer, L. (2020) *The Design Thinking Toolbox*. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley.

Bland, D.J. and Osterwalder, A. (2019) *Testing Business Ideas*. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley.